

soundreinforcement

Pilots Leave No Stone Untemplated

by Clive Young

NEW YORK, NY—In concert, Stone Temple Pilots has a formidable presence on stage, as serpentine showman Scott Weiland barks vocals backed by the athletic musicianship of the DeLeo brothers and drummer Eric Kretz. Despite this, it can be easy to underestimate the level of impact they had on turn-of-the-millennium rock—until they roll out the hits, one muscular riff after another, leaving the audience demolished by show's end.

Proving itself all over again nightly, the

reunited act has been on the road since March, touring behind its new eponymous album. Manning the mixers for the journey are Eddie Mapp at front of house and Andy Ebert in monitor world. Both engineers were on hand for the act's 2008 reunion tour, but that's not to say that the current jaunt is a photocopy of the previous one.

For starters, while the band continues to play everywhere from arenas to sheds to theaters, it's only carrying control gear and monitors provided by Clair—no PA system this time out. "This is guerilla au-



Scott Weiland leads Stone Temple Pilots through the paces nightly on the band's current tour, crooning into a Shure wireless handheld with a Heil Sound RC-35 capsule.

dio," laughed Mapp, who's been behind the board for acts like Slipknot and Evanesence. "It's fun though, because it gives you a chance to try all the PAs out there, whether it's brand-new stuff or seeing an

old box and thinking, 'Was it really as bad as I remember?'—and finding out, 'Yeah, it was.' My biggest challenge is to make left sound like right."

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Tom Petty Gets His Mojo On

NEW YORK, NY—Over the years, Tom Petty and the Heartbreakers have done it all, from New Wave to Power Pop to Classic Rock, but the band's latest album, *Mojo*, finds it exploring the R&B and Blues sounds of the Sixties. That vibe could be found onstage nightly for the band's summer tour, which wrapped up in October. The group's longtime live engineer, six-time TEC Award winner, Robert Scovill, was once again behind the house console, this time ensuring that the loose, rehearsal-like atmosphere that the album was recorded under emanated from the stage.

One aspect that helped make that happen was that both the recording pro-

cess and the live show involved Avid Venue desks—a decision that had its roots in the recording of Petty's previous album, a reunion with Mudcrutch, his pre-stardom act. "They decided to record in their warehouse space, where all the guitars, amps and everything are right there," said Scovill, who is also senior market specialist for Avid Live Sound.

"For the band, it just felt like they were rehearsing or playing, so they were really relaxed and played differently. We devised a scheme of using a Venue at the front end as a split console—half of it captured to Pro Tools at 48 kHz sampling and in another room, Ryan Ulyate, the recording engineer, worked on an Avid

Icon connected to the Pro Tools rig. The other half of the Venue was used for monitoring with [monitor engineer] Greg Looper on it, so if they wanted to punch in or wanted to listen back, they could; that freed Ryan up to mentally be completely focused on the record. Once there was success with that on the Mudcrutch album, I thought, 'They're going to do a Heartbreakers record that way'—and sure enough!"

While Scovill was unsurprisingly on a Venue desk, he switched surfaces this time out, taking a D-Show on the road with the tour. Additionally, he made some changes in the arsenal of plug-ins used throughout the show, in part to

better match the new album's sound. Scovill explained, "A lot of new ones have been released since the last time I was out; for instance, I'm using the new Waves H-Comp hybrid compressor and H-Delay analog delay plug-ins. All of Ryan's plug-in presets—all of his Massenburg stuff, his Acousticas EMT impulses, all of his delay times, everything—were imported right into the Venue from the record. There's a lot of tone shaping on the vocal that goes on, and I've tried to base at least some of what I'm doing out here on those presets; it's hard because of the gain before feedback issue, but you get some sense of what's trying to happen on the record."

Tweaking presets is a given, but Scovill was philosophical about the whys and wherefores of how effects were applied: "In my seminars, I've had students ask me many times, 'If you're in a big room,

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Stone Temple Pilots

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In order to achieve consistency night after night, Mapp has been using Rational Acoustics' new Smaart 7 software. He explained, "I have a two-space rack with two Lectrosonics wireless test and measurement systems, and a little 8-channel PreSonus FireStudio. From that, I have eight different measurement mics that I can put up at various points in the venue, so now instead of someone sitting down with the prediction software and coming up with a model that may be good for a venue, we see it for real. Sometimes it's the first time that local engineers are seeing their system all at once, finding 'Oh, maybe we should shade this down' or seeing all the different zones. It's been fun."

Both engineers oversee Avid Venue Profile consoles, and Ebert, who's handled monitors for everyone from Mariah Carey to Maceo Parker, is kept busy sending varied mixes to the band. The members of STP use both IEMs and wedges, for the most part. "We're using Sennheiser G2s because they sound nicer, a little fatter and more rock 'n' roll," Ebert opined. "Scott wears Ultimate Ears UE-7 ear buds and everyone else is on UE-11s, except the guitar player, who doesn't use in-ears. We have Showco SRM wedges for everyone except the drummer, and the sidefills are loud—stage left mainly for the guitar because he's only using sidefills and wedges. We have the old Showco sidefills flown and the wedges are under a grid downstage, so it's very neat and clean on the stage. It's fairly simple."

Less simple are the mixes Ebert sends to the band. Weiland prefers an effects-heavy presentation with lots going on, while bass and guitar get general band mixes. "Eric the drummer has full and mid ears—he doesn't have filters anymore because he likes to hear the room," reported Ebert. "He has so much ambient sound coming into his ears that he only needs certain things—a lot of bass, but far less guitar. That makes it a little strange if I listen to it, but it makes perfect sense once you sit behind the drum kit."

The stage is adorned with a variety of microphones from the likes of Audio-Technica, Sennheiser and Shure, but there's a noticeable influx of Heil mics present, including a prototype of the company's upcoming PR 31. "It's a brand-new, large-diaphragm, dynamic microphone—basically a PR-30 but in a much smaller housing," said Ebert. "I started using it for overheads, where the better rear rejection blends out a lot of unwanted noise coming from the rest of the stage and you only hear crystal-clear cymbals and a little bit of drums. On the bass cabinets, it has a much tighter low end and low-mid sound than anything I've ever used before."

The arrival of the modern personal studio has resulted in legions of musicians who can now discuss their live sound with engineers more accurately, but there's



Monitor man Andy Ebert (left) and FOH engineer Eddie Mapp, before another STP show.

been a lesser-appreciated side effect that affects a band's live show as well, as Mapp noted. "Scott, Eric and Robert each have their own studios, so when they're in rehearsals, they're real comfortable with the way it sounds because it's nice and tight in a small room," said Mapp. "When we start getting to big stages, they're really sensitive to low end. For me to get the

'push' I need from the subs to get through the audience can often be a fight with how that's affecting the stage."

As a result, Mapp has been using the "PA of the Day" experience to learn more about how to implement cardioid subs with different systems, but readily pointed out that there's a lot of variables at play, from prep time to stage surface to space in the venue to local crews that may not be familiar with the concept. "It's hard to tell before we line check whether it works," he admitted. "And even where the subs are working, sometimes there's low-end build up in the center, or the left or right. The guitar player is OK with a little more low end tickling the feet, but the bass player doesn't like it at all. Scott's OK with it, so we have to shift that around."

The band is shifting around West Coast, Canadian and Mexican venues until the end of this month, before a brief run through South America in December. At each show, the band will be serving up selections from its new album along with the old favorites, giving everyone in the house an opportunity to rock out. "Take 'Pretty Penny,'" said Mapp. "It's just a fun, mean, hard-hitting song that wakes everybody up and it's got enough space to allow it to be big and breathe. All their old classic stuff, it's still fun for me to hear because that's what I grew up listening to!"

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Tozzoli

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articulations, depending on how hard and/or fast you hit the keyboard.

Of importance is the fact that with most patches in HS, CC#11 (expression pedal) is used for dynamics, whereas CC#1 (mod wheel) is used for vibrato. However, CC#11 is not just traditional MIDI volume like in other libraries; it actually cross-fades between real dynamics. When sitting down at the keyboard and playing with an expression controller and the mod wheel, it took a little getting used to. However, the results, once learned, sound magnificent.

Running Play within Pro Tools 8.1, I was able to take advantage of such things as measured tremolo articulations, where the patch actually syncs to the song tempo. Yes, it uses time-stretch manipulations, but it really does work. They also nicely followed tempo changes—a reality in any kind of TV/media/film work. Working with *con sordino* ("with the mute"), it uses EQ to "filter" the samples, but again, it gets the job done. There is so much in this library already, you simply can't have everything.

It also takes a little time to learn the patch nomenclature of HS, but it's actually quite easy once you understand it. Users have a choice over such things as finger positions, voices per note (up to 16!), down bows, up bows, round robins and so on. In sampling terms, round robin is an important factor where the software engine automatically alternates between separate recordings of the same note, providing a more realistic sound.

I like that several different "microphones" per patch can be loaded (of course using up more RAM with each one). Close, Mid, Main (Decca Tree), Vin-

tage or Surround each has its own sonic depth and character and can be individually mixed/panned/output to create a customized blend. My personal favorite was to use a combination of Mid and Vintage with a touch of Main. It delivers a super-warm, wide image that when combined with the built-in reverb, is simply stunning. But since they do take up a lot of RAM, I often found myself printing the track and hiding the MIDI. I could then go back and re-render the track with any combination of mic positions later on.

Speaking of reverb, it can be assigned to individual patches or across the Master to conserve DSP. The production team recorded all its own convolution verbs and many are new impulses right from the Quantum Leap Spaces collection. Reverb is critical to good string sounds, and there are some excellent ones included, my favorites being the Burbank Scoring Stage Medium and EW Hall + Church.

System requirements, as you might expect for a product of this nature, can get heavy. Check out the website at soundsonline.com for specifics relating to your system. Certainly, you'll want a ton of RAM and a fast computer/drive setup, or frustration will set in quickly. However, there is a Gold Edition also available in 16-bit resolution with a single mid-tree mic position.

As the useful Hollywood Strings Diamond Edition video tutorials clearly mention, it's a large and complex library. But they have done a great job to make the user experience quite simple. If you're looking for a top-tier software instrument to re-create strings, this is the one to turn to. While this product is not cheap, coming in at nearly \$1,500, I'll say it one more time: "Wow."

An audio sample of Rich Tozzoli's work with *Hollywood Strings* is available at prosoundnews.com/blog/32228.

Saltlands

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Salet notes. "That's how we start to help each other out, because we're all building our own commercial studios and our own careers. That's where we share knowledge and contacts—and manual labor."

"In terms of rehearsal," he adds, "we've had great bands come through over the years—Animal Collective, the Walkmen, Guster, Fischerspooner. That's important to having a successful studio, too: being in contact with a lot of different musicians, being aware of what's going on, and just getting to know people."

"That's what Steve is mostly about,"

says Greenwood. "He could be making a killing on these spaces if he divided them all up and ran bands in and out. But it's more important to him to build a community and a collective of people that he admires and enjoys being with. And it's going to produce something remarkable in the upcoming years. I think some influential work will come out of this space."

"I'm sure he is too modest about this," Maurer adds, "but I think Steve was instrumental in the DUMBO scene here."

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